

HIST 312 Examination

Modern European and World History (1789–1945) – Answer Key

1. **(B)** Wilson's Fourteen Points.
President Woodrow Wilson's Fourteen Points (January 1918) emphasized national self-determination, calling for the adjustment of colonial claims with consideration for the peoples concerned. This principle shaped the redrawing of European boundaries after WWI, though imperfectly implemented.
2. **(A)** Overproduction and underconsumption combined with speculation and credit expansion.
The 1920s saw overproduction in agriculture and industry, speculation in stocks (buying on margin), and unequal wealth distribution limiting consumption. When the stock market crashed in October 1929, credit contracted, demand collapsed, and the downward spiral began.
3. **(B)** The French Revolution (1789).
The French Revolution's principles of liberty, equality, and fraternity, along with popular sovereignty replacing divine right, inspired revolutionary and nationalist movements across Europe throughout the 19th century.
4. **(B)** Neville Chamberlain.
Chamberlain pursued appeasement, most notably agreeing to German annexation of the Sudetenland at the Munich Conference (September 1938), believing it would preserve peace. The policy failed when Hitler invaded Czechoslovakia and Poland.
5. *Sample answer:*
Causes:
 - Agricultural improvements freed labor for industry
 - Capital accumulation from trade and colonialism
 - Technological innovations: steam engine, mechanized textile production, iron and steel advances
 - Coal and iron resources, especially in Britain
 - Political stability and favorable legal frameworks (property rights, patents)**Economic transformation:**
 - Shift from agrarian to industrial economy
 - Factory system replaced cottage industry
 - Mass production lowered costs, increased output
 - Expansion of trade and transportation (railroads, steamships)**Social consequences:**
 - Urbanization: mass migration to cities (Manchester, Birmingham)
 - Emergence of industrial working class with poor conditions (long hours, child labor, unsafe factories)
 - Growth of middle class (factory owners, merchants, professionals)

- Social problems: overcrowding, disease, pollution

Political effects:

- Rise of labor movements and trade unions demanding reforms
- Emergence of socialist ideologies (Marx, Engels)
- Reform legislation: Factory Acts limiting work hours, improving conditions
- Extension of suffrage as industrial workers gained political voice

6. Sample answer:

Origins: Established at the Congress of Vienna (1814–1815) after Napoleon’s defeat. The major powers (Austria, Britain, Prussia, Russia, later France) agreed to meet periodically to maintain the balance of power and suppress revolutionary movements.

Principles:

- **Legitimacy:** Restore legitimate monarchs overthrown by Napoleon
- **Balance of power:** Ensure no single power dominates Europe
- **Collective security:** Major powers intervene to prevent revolution and maintain order
- **Conservatism:** Preserve traditional institutions against liberal and nationalist movements

Significance: Maintained relative peace in Europe (1815–1854), preventing general war. Congresses at Aix-la-Chapelle, Troppau, and Verona addressed crises.

Limitations:

- Could not permanently suppress nationalism and liberalism
- Britain withdrew from interventionist policies (Crimean War broke the system)
- Ignored aspirations of people for self-determination
- Eventually undermined by nationalist movements (Italian and German unification, Greek independence)

7. Sample answer:

Alliance system:

- Triple Alliance: Germany, Austria-Hungary, Italy (1882)
- Triple Entente: France, Russia, Britain (1907)
- Created rigid, interlocking commitments that turned a regional crisis into a general war

Militarism:

- Arms race, especially naval competition between Britain and Germany
- Large standing armies with mobilization plans (Schlieffen Plan)
- Military leaders influenced policy, favored offensive strategies

Imperialism:

- Competition for colonies in Africa and Asia created tensions

- Moroccan crises (1905, 1911) between France and Germany
- Desire for resources, markets, and prestige

Nationalism:

- Balkan nationalism destabilized Austria-Hungary (Slavic peoples seeking independence)
- Pan-Slavism (Russian support for Slavs) vs. Pan-Germanism
- Assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand by Serbian nationalist (June 1914) triggered the war

These factors created a powder keg; the assassination provided the spark.

8. *Sample answer:*

Common factors across regimes:

- Economic crisis and instability (postwar chaos, Great Depression)
- Weak democratic institutions or traditions
- Fear of communism or social revolution
- National humiliation or unfulfilled nationalist aspirations
- Use of mass propaganda and modern communication
- Charismatic leadership exploiting crises

Italy (Mussolini, 1922):

- Postwar economic problems, unemployment, strikes
- Fear of socialist revolution
- Disappointment over “mutilated victory” (territorial gains at Versailles)
- Weak liberal government unable to maintain order
- Mussolini’s Fascist squadristi used violence against socialists

Germany (Hitler, 1933):

- Treaty of Versailles seen as humiliating (war guilt, reparations, territorial losses)
- Hyperinflation (1923) destroyed middle-class savings
- Great Depression: massive unemployment (6 million by 1932)
- Weak Weimar democracy with proportional representation
- Hitler promised restoration of German greatness, scapegoated Jews

Soviet Union (Stalin, 1920s–1930s):

- Bolshevik seizure of power created one-party state (1917)
- Civil War (1918–1921) militarized politics
- Lenin’s death (1924) led to power struggle; Stalin eliminated rivals
- Collectivization and industrialization enforced through terror
- No democratic tradition, tsarist legacy of autocracy

All three leaders consolidated power through propaganda, secret police, suppression of opposition, and cult of personality.